Destiny or Aggression?

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

To many Americans in the 1840s, spreading across the continent was the nation's God-given destiny. To win it, the United States fought a war that doubled its size — and that some of its own greatest figures called a crime. This is the war as America told it.

A continent for the taking

In the 1840s, a confident young United States looked west and saw its future. From the Atlantic to the Pacific, Americans came to believe, the continent was theirs to settle, farm, and govern — by right, and by the will of God.

That belief had a name, and it would carry the country into a war with its southern neighbor — a war that added California, Texas, and the whole Southwest to the map, and that reopened the one question the nation could not answer: where would slavery be allowed to grow?

"American Progress" by John Gast, 1872 — a glowing figure of Columbia leads settlers, railroads, and telegraph wires west, as Native peoples and buffalo flee into the dark. Painting, public domain (Library of Congress).

"Manifest Destiny"

The phrase Manifest Destiny gave a comfortable name to something that was already happening. It said that American expansion was not conquest but destiny — obvious ("manifest"), inevitable, and blessed.

It was a powerful idea precisely because it turned taking land into a kind of duty. If the continent was meant to be American, then settlers moving west, and even an army marching south, were only helping destiny along. The people already living on that land — Mexicans and Native nations — barely appeared in the picture.

"Mexican Treacheries and Cruelties" — a sensational account of the war sold cheaply to the American public, stoking outrage at the enemy. Pamphlet, 1847, public domain (source to confirm).

Texas and a disputed river

Texas had broken away from Mexico in 1836 and declared itself an independent republic. Mexico never accepted it. So when the United States annexed Texas in 1845, bringing it in as a state, Mexico saw it as the theft of its own territory.

Then came the match. Texas claimed its southern border was the Rio Grande; Mexico said the border had always been the Nueces River, about 150 miles farther north. The strip of land between the two rivers was claimed by both countries — and President James K. Polk, who wanted California too, ordered American troops to march into it.

The border in dispute — the Republic of Texas and the land claimed by both Mexico and Texas, with the Santa Fe Trail running through it. Map, public domain (source to confirm).

“American blood on American soil”

In April 1846, Mexican cavalry crossed the Rio Grande and clashed with an American patrol in the disputed zone, killing or capturing several soldiers. It was the opening Polk needed.

Congress declared war within days. But Polk’s version — that Mexico had attacked America on American ground — depended entirely on the claim that the land between the rivers was already the United States. A young congressman named Abraham Lincoln would soon demand to know the exact spot where American blood had supposedly been shed.

President James K. Polk (1795–1849), who led the United States into the war and oversaw the largest expansion of its territory in a single term. Portrait, public domain (Library of Congress).

Mr. Polk’s war

Polk’s strategy had three arms. General Zachary Taylor would drive south across the Rio Grande into northern Mexico. A smaller force under Stephen Kearny would seize New Mexico and push on to California, where American settlers were already in revolt. And if Mexico still would not make peace, General Winfield Scott would land on the Gulf coast and march on the capital itself.

It was an astonishingly ambitious plan for a nation with a tiny professional army — and, battle by battle, it worked.

“Battle of the Plains of Mesa,” California, 9 January 1847 — the far-western front, where U.S. forces under Stockton and Kearny fought for California. Watercolor, public domain (source to confirm).

Taylor’s war

Taylor won victory after victory — at Palo Alto, at Resaca de la Palma, and in brutal street fighting at Monterrey. Then, in February 1847, Santa Anna hurled a Mexican army more than twice the size of Taylor’s at him near a mountain pass called Buena Vista.

Taylor held. The victory made “Old Rough and Ready” a national hero — famous enough that, two years later, Americans would elect him president. But the war was not won in the north. To end it, the United States would have to take Mexico City.

“Battle of Buena Vista,” February 1847 — Zachary Taylor’s outnumbered army holds off Santa Anna in northern Mexico. Lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

The bombardment of Veracruz

Winfield Scott landed some 12,000 men on the beaches near Veracruz — the first large amphibious landing in American history — and laid siege to the walled city. For days, American guns shelled it until it surrendered.

The bombardment killed Mexican soldiers and civilians alike, and some American officers were uneasy about it. But the port was the gateway inland, and Scott now had his road. From Veracruz he would follow

the same route Hernán Cortés had taken three centuries before — up from the coast toward the great city in the mountains.

The U.S. bombardment of Veracruz, March 1847 — Scott's first step on the road to Mexico City. Lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

The halls of Montezuma

Scott fought his way inland and, in September 1847, stormed the heights of Chapultepec, the castle and military school guarding Mexico City. The next day American forces marched into the Mexican capital and raised the United States flag over the National Palace.

It was the triumph that gave the U.S. Marines the opening line of their hymn — "from the halls of Montezuma." For the United States, the war was effectively won. For Mexico, the enemy now held the heart of the nation.

"The Storming of Chapultepec," 13 September 1847 — American troops assault the castle guarding Mexico City. Lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

Half a nation changes hands

The Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo ended the war in 1848. Mexico ceded roughly 525,000 square miles — about half its national territory — to the United States: all of California, Nevada, and Utah, and much of Arizona, New Mexico, Colorado, and Wyoming. In return the United States paid $15 million and assumed some debts.

In a single treaty, the United States grew by a third and reached the Pacific. The dream of a continental nation, from sea to sea, was suddenly real. Manifest Destiny had delivered.

The Mexican Cession of 1848 — the vast territory Mexico ceded to the United States, shown against the modern state lines it would become. Map, public domain (Library of Congress).

"One of the most unjust"

Not every American cheered. The war split the country. Many in the North saw it as a naked land grab driven by slaveholders hungry for new cotton territory. Abraham Lincoln challenged Polk's story with his "Spot Resolutions," demanding the president name the exact spot where American blood had first been shed. The writer Henry David Thoreau went to jail rather than pay a tax that funded the war, and wrote Civil Disobedience about it.

So even in the American telling, this is not a simple story of glory. It is a war the nation won completely and argued about bitterly — and whose greatest soldier spent the rest of his life uneasy about it.

"An Available Candidate: The One Qualification for a Whig President" — a bitter 1848 cartoon seating a war-hero general on a mountain of the dead. Lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

The land that broke the country

The new territory was supposed to be a triumph. Instead it became the thing that tore the Union apart. Every acre raised the same furious question: would it be free or slave?

Even before the war ended, a congressman named David Wilmot proposed banning slavery in any land taken from Mexico — the Wilmot Proviso. It failed, but it drew the battle lines. The Compromise of 1850,

“Bleeding Kansas,” the Dred Scott decision — all of it grew from the problem of what to do with the land this war had won.

Destiny, or aggression?

Here is the hard part. The same war can be told as the fulfillment of a national destiny — or as a powerful country inventing an excuse to take a weaker neighbor’s land. Both tellings use real facts. They simply choose different ones to stand on.

Historians call this skill point of view: asking not just what happened but who is telling it, what they want you to believe, and who disappears from their version. You have just read the war largely as the United States remembered it. In the companion assignment, you will read it from the Mexican side — and then decide for yourself.